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The Maasai of Matapato

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With the disbanding ceremony, the ritual of rebellion symbolised by the whole manyata episode is over. Indeed, it seems likely that it must be a spent force before there can be sufficient accommodation between moran and elders even to mount *eunoto*, let alone disband the manyat. Both moran and patrons would undermine premature attempts before this point. Richard Waller (personal communication) has suggested that this disbanding ceremony may well go beyond a 'merely ritualistic attack'. The Terito^R age-group in Loita told him that when they were moran, they were terrorised by one of the patrons who sat outside their rebel manyata with a firestick over his knee and asked repeatedly: 'Do I break it? Do I break it?' Magical elements in the patrons' threats were held to have led to monkeys invading the manyata and to lions lying down on the beds of moran. This incidentally was the age-group that defied their patrons by building their manyat in the first place, and they appear to have been threatened with the withdrawal of the patrons' mystical protection, leaving them exposed to the untamed forces of the bush (qv. Case 24).⁸

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After moran have dispersed to their fathers' villages to 'drink milk', the manyata site is gradually eroded by the natural encroachment of the bush. The lionskin trophies too lose their glamour after *eunoto*. They can no longer be displayed and are discarded as mere toys. They may be handed on to younger [166](#) brothers to give them a final display at their *enkipaata* dance, when the new age-set is inaugurated. Then after initiation they too will refuse to wear trophies that they have not themselves earned as moran in their own lion hunts. They are again discarded and either thrown away or with luck sold

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to tourists seeking their own Maasai trophies according to their own notions of prestige.

The most graphic description offered of the disbanding ceremony was among the Loitokitok Maasai where it is still deferred until the next age-set have been initiated years after *eunoto*. Forty-nine firestick patrons cowl their heads with sheepskin caps, *inkureeta*, whence the name of the ceremony, *enoonkureeta*. Their abuses against the moran incorporate such phrases as: 'become bitter; be finished off; become lost for ever; you have fucked your mothers when they denied us [this right]; I have come and hear and see that your mother has nothing left to fuck'. As with the joking between moran and their mothers at the first forest ox (of-the-earplugs), the Matapato acknowledged but did not stress the element of joking abuse. The disbanding ceremony appears to have lapsed among the Purko, and its future is uncertain in Matapato.

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